

does a great job in highlighting the keypad. It looks great, especially in the dark. The feel of the plastic keys, however, leaves a lot to be desired.

The screen supports 65K colours, but in contrast to several Samsung and LG phones, the screen is dull and has poor colour vibrancy. Also, the screen is extremely small despite the fact that there is more than enough space for a large screen. The integrated VGA camera can click at 640 x 480. The pictures we got were sharp and bright.

Connectivity options include infrared, GPRS and WAP 2.0. An FM receiver with a stereo headset is bundled along for added fun.

The user interface is classic Nokia. The menu is responsive and fast compared to other Nokia phones. It's only when opening media files that you experience some lag. The camera can also be used to record clips up to 50 seconds long. The voice recorder allows for a three-minute long recording, and recordings can be set as ringtones.

Ringtone volume is quite low, and you're sure to miss a couple of calls in noisy environs. However, the vibrator is powerful enough to make up for the low ring volume. Games such as Bowling should keep you busy while you're travelling.

Nokia 7600

Price: Rs 26,939 C

The wackiest design ever on a phone to hit the market comes in the form of Nokia's 7600. Love it or hate it, the Nokia 7600 sports the most original design of them all and is a real attention-grabber.

The design is largely square, with the two opposite ends each tapered into a smooth curve that gives this phone what they call a 'leaf design'. The screen comes in exactly at the centre, flanked by buttons on either side. You need to hold the phone diagonally when speaking. The phone is unusually wide—this rules out one-handed operation.

The keys are arranged in a linear fashion along the screen, and it's hard to find the right key at the first go. Moreover, the keys are more hard, and completely lack tactile feedback. The four-directional pad and the soft-keys are better though messaging is a pain on this phone.

The menu structure is borrowed from the series 40 phones—the 6610, 6100 etc. However, the icons are a complete let-down, given the fact that the phone has a 65K colour screen capable of delivering vibrant images.

The 7600 can play MP3, AAC and MIDI sounds formats, and you can also set such files as ringtones. Files can be transferred via Bluetooth or infrared. The phone has 29 MB of internal memory that cannot be supplemented by MMC cards.

The integrated camera is quite good by cell phone standards, and lets you capture clips as well as still images. Clips can be as long as two and half minutes. One other unique feature of this phone is that it is WCDMA-capable, meaning that in the near future, as networks begin supporting such high bandwidth, you can access services at faster data rates.



All these features and the original look, however, does not come cheap, and the phone will set you back by Rs 26,939. If you're the type that likes to portray individuality and doesn't care about the money, the Nokia 7600 fits the bill perfectly.

Siemens S55

Price: Rs 12,700 A-

Weighing just 85 gm, the S55 marks Siemens' entry into the business category of mobile phones. The S55 replaces the S45, and comes with new features such as tri-band GSM, MMS, Bluetooth, Java, polyphonic ringtones, and a full-featured PIM.

Priced at Rs 12,700, the S55 is a great phone with solid features, but it's a primitive 256-colour display is a letdown. The screen severely limits the usability of the phone and does not do a bit of justice to the otherwise perfectly-balanced feature set.

The subtle use of chrome on select keys adds a touch of style and contrasts well with the grey keypad. In fact, it's the keypad that gives the S55 its uniqueness. The keys are arranged in layers that form ridges as you go down, each layer perfectly separated from the other. The only gripe we had was with the lowest layer, where the keys are too small.

The camera is an external snap-on. It is capable of a resolution of 640 x 480, but the pictures we captured looked dull and of low quality on the phone's display. The camera features a flash.

The provided cable comes as a great help when using the phone as a GPRS modem. Bluetooth works seamlessly. The voice recorder is good, and the voice command feature works well. Messaging is simple and fast. The menu interface is classic Siemens, with coloured icons, and make no mistake: the interface is as simple and easy to use as a Nokia.



Siemens M55

Price: Rs 9,900 A

Siemens, with its M55, has come out with a hip phone that should appeal to the younger generation. Priced at Rs 9,900, the M55 offers a youthful, dynamic design with good features bundled.

The tone for the looks is set by flashy orange buttons on a silver-grey background cover. The earpiece also gets some orange treatment in an 'X' shape, with silver grille inserts that pop out and literally grab attention. To accentuate the trendy look, you have red LEDs blinking on both sides of the phone.

Functionality is, however, not compromised upon. The keys are responsive and have reasonable tactile feedback. The only gripe is the tiny power on/off button and the answer button. The menu rocker and the soft-keys are usable, but may not be as comfortable as other phones in this category.

The outer body shell provides shock protection; on the inside, the M55 is very much like its brethren—the screen is again 4K

